

to the internet; the dark web is one such network. To access it you need to hop onto a different set of routers, which are isolated from the internet that we know. There exist a vast number of websites that unfortunately have had no authority keeping a watchful eye on them. The dark web is where you can access information that's normally censored and taken down by governments but it's also a host to websites that indulge in narcotics and assassins for hire.

We don't need to worry about the planned second internet turning out the same way, since the member nations will initiate policing as they've done before. That last statement seemed like a paradox, didn't it? That's because the folks in power always have an agenda and they aren't a lovely bunch either. Take Russia for example; it has a website blacklist which not only censors illegal content like pornography but also goes out of its way to censor stuff deemed not worthy of being in the public domain. This includes criticism against the government as well. India isn't that transparent or ahead of Russia either. In the recently released Web Index 2013 statistics – measuring the internet's contribution to development and human rights in countries worldwide – India has been ranked 56 out of 81 countries. This highlights poor internet infrastructure penetration and a rather free-handed censorship style. The importance of a free and open internet only lies on paper and isn't understood by policy makers of the country. The IT Act of 2000 is a clear indication of this, wherein the infamous Section 66A is so broadly defined that it's been abused to arrest people for simple emails and Facebook posts.



Seems like Grumpy cat would be the first to switch

Apparently Geopolitics is a thing

As mentioned before, this wouldn't be the first time the oppressed have moved on to create a world of their own. The laying of another cable has a lot more to offer than just increased speed and reduced latency. For one, the BRICS countries will have an option, and arm twisting these nations by withholding resources will be a lot more difficult. Then there are the many backward countries in Africa for whom the improved connectivity will mean globalisation of the region, which in turn will help accelerate development.

If you went back in history, you'd remember the time when France and Germany argued for telegraph lines separate from British influence (Britain was the major stakeholder in the telegraph market) and look where they are now. Though internet connectivity isn't some voodoo magic which improves

the economy in a day, it does help boost information exchange and economic activity which subsequently aids in growth of a nation. The scales of power stand to change because of the emergence of choice in all matters. Not having a bargaining chip in the region leads to loss of influence which means a few decades down the line the political scenario may radically change.

The impact

Reduced surveillance on the part of the United States will be one of the payoffs. Since the cable does connect to the US at Miami the two networks (Internet and the Second Internet) will be connected but majority of the information will pass between the member nations and only those targeted to foreign servers will actually be under scrutiny from external security agencies. And if the vote in Brazil over localised data storage does pass, then this data exchange will be even lesser. Even Google considered moving its servers out of the US after the Snowden incident.

This new means of internet access also enables the architects of the second internet to increase its transparency and security. Making HTTPS the default standard for internet traffic is the simplest way to go. At a recent event Google's CEO Eric Schmidt expressed his optimism over the elimination of censorship on the internet, saying that it could be accomplished over the next decade. More countries have the option of opting in to the second network, thus providing an opportunity to engage with



That red line is 34,000 kilometers long and would be the backbone of the Second Internet